Digital IMPACT

BY THE DIGITAL CITIZENSHIP AMBASSADORS

SAC
SEV AMERICAN COLLEGE
ÖZEL SEV LİSESİ

SAC
SEV AMERICAN COLLEGE
ÖZEL SEV LİSESİ

Editorial Director *Alize G.*

Digital Citizenship Ambassador Leader

Number 2

March 20

Istanbul

Sev American College

From The Editor

The Modern Day Puppeteers: An in-depth analysis of your screen time

The Psychological and Communicative Impacts of Social Media in the Digital Age: Challenges and Pathways Forward

The "Doomscrolling" Paradox

The Loneliest Generation: How Screens Replaced Conversations

Works Cited

From The Editor

What is digital identity and digital security?

The profile pictures, avatars, usernames, posts, and comments we use online all form our digital identity. In other words, they represent who we are in the digital world.

However, it is important to ensure that this information and these interactions are not misused by malicious individuals. To stay safe online, several precautions are necessary, such as:

- Improving digital literacy skills
- Creating safer digital environments
- Reducing online risks

So, how can we protect ourselves from these risks?

By understanding our legal responsibilities, staying informed about technological developments, and learning how to behave responsibly online. Being aware of our rights and obligations in the digital space is essential. With this in mind, we decided to prepare this school magazine to share up-to-date information, legal insights, and current news with you.

We hope this magazine will be useful for everyone, and we look forward to your support and feedback.

In this issue:

- What is digital identity? How should we use it?
- What are the risks of social media use? How can we protect ourselves from them?



Alize G.

Digital Citizenship Ambassador Leader



The Psychological Cost of the Digital Mirror

Social media has transformed into a massive stage where we unconsciously compare our daily struggles with everyone else's carefully curated successes. This environment often triggers specific psychological stress factors. Some of them are:

1 - Fear of missing out & digital social comparison:

While often dismissed as simple envy, fear of missing out also known as FOMO in 2026 is a structural psychological phenomenon. It is fueled by the specifically selected reality gap. The distance between our unedited lives and the perfect versions of others we see online. This gap creates a false narrative that everyone else is living a more successful or exciting life which leads to persistent feelings of inadequacy and lower life satisfaction.

2 - The modern digital landscape operates on a feedback based reward system.

When our self worth is tied to metrics like likes, shares or comments it creates a neurological dependency. This constant search for validation from others does erode internal self confidence and make our emotional state vulnerable to the unpredictable reactions of an online audience.

3 - Despite being more connected than ever, many individuals report higher levels of social isolation.

High frequency and low depth interactions such as scrolling or reactive to stories often replace the meaningful face to face conversation that are necessary for true emotional support.



The digital world has made communication instantaneous but it has also made it thinner. By removing non verbal cues such as tone of voice, facial expressions and body language the change for misunderstanding increases. In professional and personal relationships the reliance on digital text often leads to a decline in empathy and the nuance required fır resolving social complex issues.



To counter these psychological pressures we must move from passive scrolling to active management of our digital habits. This shift is most critical during the margins of our day those sensitive windows immediately after waking and right before sleep. When the brain is most vulnerable to social comparison immediately after waking and right before sleep. Create a strict rule that disallows you to look at the screen for the first 60 minutes of the day and the last 60 minutes before bed. This allows your mind to ground itself in your own reality before engaging with the specially selected lives of others.

Barış Y.

Digital Citizenship Ambassador Leader Assistant

The Psychological and Communicative Impacts of Social Media in the Digital Age

Challenges and Pathways Forward

The digital world grew really fast, and social media changed how we learn things, how we see ourselves, and how we talk to other people. These platforms let us connect and share information like never before, but they also create serious psychological and communication problems. This article looks at how social media affects mental health and the way we interact with each other, and it suggests some practical solutions to deal with the bad stuff.

Our everyday lives are basically digital now. A lot of our communication moved from physical spaces to virtual ones. Social media is a huge part of that, and it acts as a tool for sharing knowledge, but it’s also where we build our identities. This shift makes you think about some important questions. Like, can we trust our perception when it’s filtered through a screen? How do biases affect what we believe? And what is this doing to our mental health and communication skills in the long run?

Social Media Addiction and Emotional Exhaustion

Studies show that using social media too much is connected to emotional exhaustion. When people are addicted to scrolling, they experience cognitive overload and decision fatigue. You start to feel disconnected from real life. This happens because you're constantly looking at curated information, which messes with your perception of what's normal or successful. Eventually, you just feel dissatisfied and burned out.



Depression, Anxiety, and Loneliness

Social media is basically a place where everyone shows the best parts of their life like it's reality. This creates a biased way of comparing yourself to others. You measure your own worth against standards that aren't even real.

Research shows this leads to more depression, anxiety, and loneliness. It's kind of ironic that platforms meant to bring us together actually make us feel more isolated.

Self-Perception and Identity Construction

Digital platforms really affect how we see ourselves and how we present our identity. The line between your authentic self and the self you perform online gets super blurry. You start tailoring your online persona to fit what you think other people expect. This shows how much perspective and audience shape the way we see ourselves. A lot of times, this causes internal conflict and lowers your self-esteem.

Decline of Face-to-Face Interaction

Digital communication is so convenient that people don’t really talk in person anymore. Texting and DMs let you share information fast, but they don’t have the emotional depth of actually being with someone. This shift makes it harder to empathize with people because you lose the ability to read non-verbal cues. Those cues are actually essential for real communication.



Increased Social Anxiety

It’s weird, but using social media a lot can actually make your social anxiety worse. You get so comfortable talking behind a screen that real-world interactions start to feel scary. You become dependent on mediated communication, and you start avoiding face-to-face situations. This just limits your interpersonal skills even more.

Superficial Relationships and Filtered Communication

Online interactions are usually pretty shallow. People use filters, both literal and metaphorical, to control how they're perceived. But that takes away authenticity. When everyone is curating their image, the relationships you form online end up lacking depth. It makes you question whether these connections are actually reliable for real understanding.



4. Positive Dimensions of Social Media

Even with all the problems, social media does have good sides. It lets you communicate with people around the world, gives you access to different perspectives, and helps information spread quickly. So in a way, it's a powerful tool for building collective knowledge and exchanging culture. If you use it carefully, it can strengthen relationships and create support systems that go beyond borders.

5. Proposed Solutions and Future Considerations

Digital Awareness and Media Literacy

People need to understand how digital content is made and how they consume it. You have to recognize that bias, algorithms, and selective representation are shaping your perception. Media literacy helps you question the reliability of information and engage with digital spaces more thoughtfully.

Conscious and Purposeful Usage

You should limit your screen time and actually be intentional about how you use social media. Instead of just mindlessly scrolling, you can engage with content that actually matters to you and contributes to learning or real connection.

Rebalancing Human Interaction

It’s really important to encourage face-to-face communication and real-world social stuff. Direct interaction helps build empathy, strengthens relationships, and gives you a more authentic understanding of other people.

Algorithmic Awareness

Knowing how algorithms curate your content can help you avoid echo chambers. If you actively look for diverse viewpoints, you can challenge your own assumptions and get a more balanced understanding of reality.

The digital world, especially social media, plays a huge role in how we experience life. It affects how we see ourselves, how we build knowledge, and how we relate to other people. The psychological and communication challenges are real, but they're not impossible to fix. Through critical reflection, being intentional about your usage, and trying to find balance, you can navigate the digital world in a way that actually improves your well-being and relationships instead of harming them.

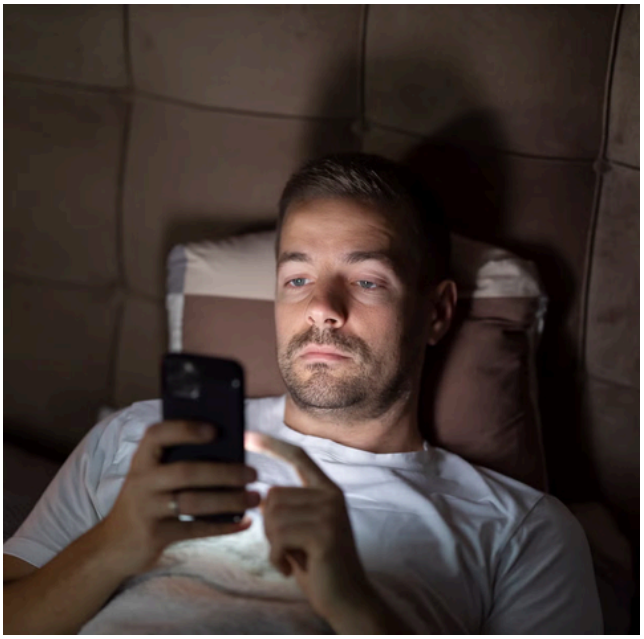
Mete Alp Ü.

Digital Citizenship Ambassador

The "Doomscrolling" Paradox

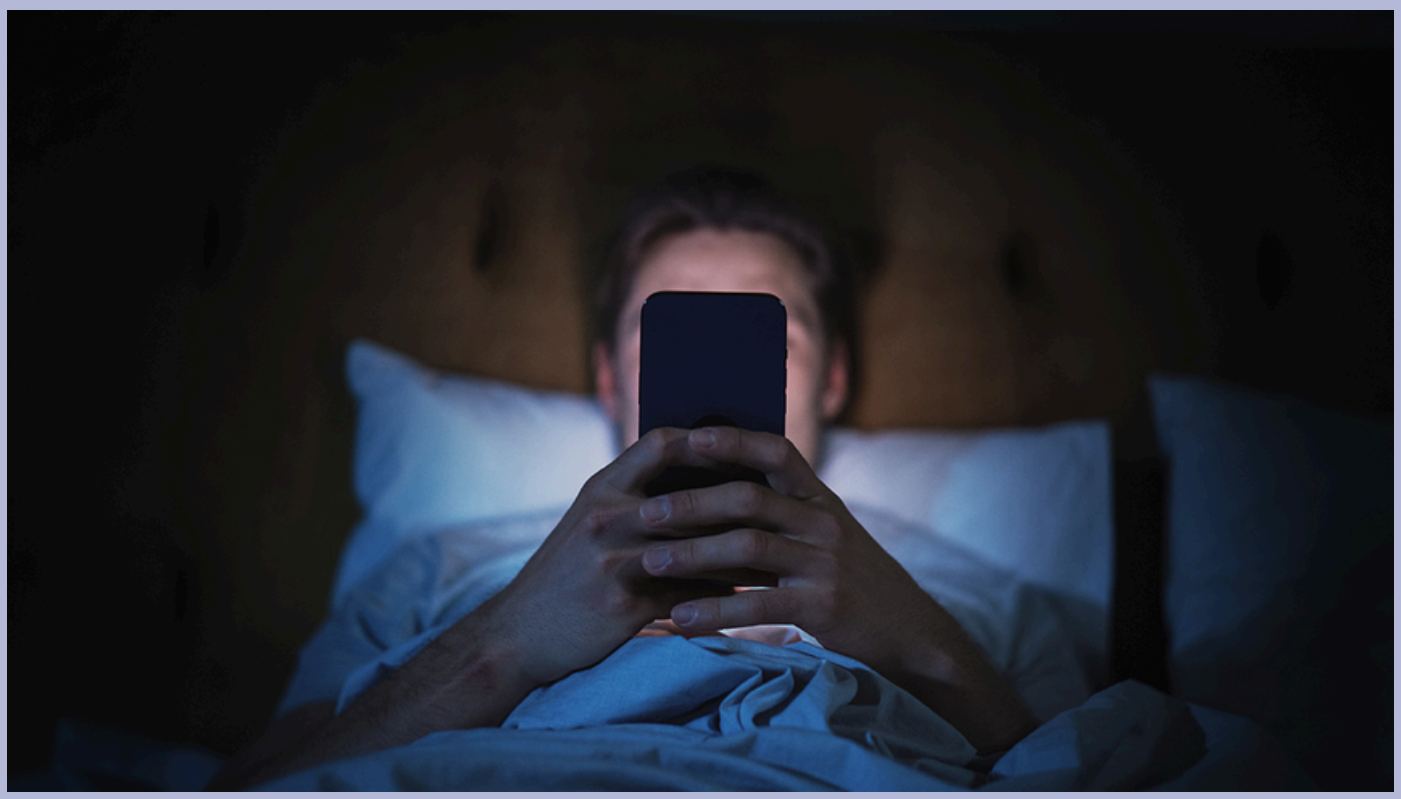
The phenomenon of "doomscrolling" represents a profound shift in how humans process information, where the act of endlessly consuming negative digital content begins to fundamentally rewire our psychological resilience. This behavior is deeply rooted in an evolutionary mechanism known as the negativity bias, which originally served to keep our ancestors alert to physical threats but has now been hijacked by the infinite nature of social media feeds. Because our brains are biologically programmed to prioritize survival information over positive data, we find ourselves trapped in a loop of seeking out distressing news under the misplaced belief that "knowing more" equates to being safer.

This evolutionary trap leads directly into a physiological state of chronic hyper-vigilance, as the constant stream of crisis imagery triggers a persistent release of cortisol and adrenaline. Unlike a physical threat that eventually passes, the digital world offers no resolution, keeping the amygdala in a state of permanent alarm.



Consequently, this neurological taxation exhausts our cognitive resources, making it increasingly difficult to engage in the high-level emotional regulation required for healthy daily functioning

The impact of this mental exhaustion extends far beyond the individual, severely degrading the quality of interpersonal communication and social cohesion. When a person is saturated with global-scale anxieties, they often experience "compassion fatigue," a state where the emotional bandwidth for empathy toward friends and family is depleted by the sheer volume of distant tragedies. This often manifests as "phubbing" or irritability in physical spaces, as the individual becomes more tethered to the urgent, digital simulation of crisis than to the nuanced, quiet reality of the people sitting directly across from them.



To mitigate these corrosive effects, it is essential to transition from passive consumption to intentional digital boundaries by implementing "friction" into the scrolling experience. One effective approach involves setting a physical timer or utilizing greyscale display settings to strip the interface of its neurological rewards, thereby breaking the trance-like state of the infinite scroll. Furthermore, rebalancing one's digital diet by consciously seeking out solution-oriented or local community content can help restore a sense of agency that global news often strips away. Ultimately, by reclaiming our attention from the algorithm, we can move away from a state of paralyzed observation and return to a life defined by active, meaningful engagement with the physical world.

Mert G.

Digital Citizenship Ambassador

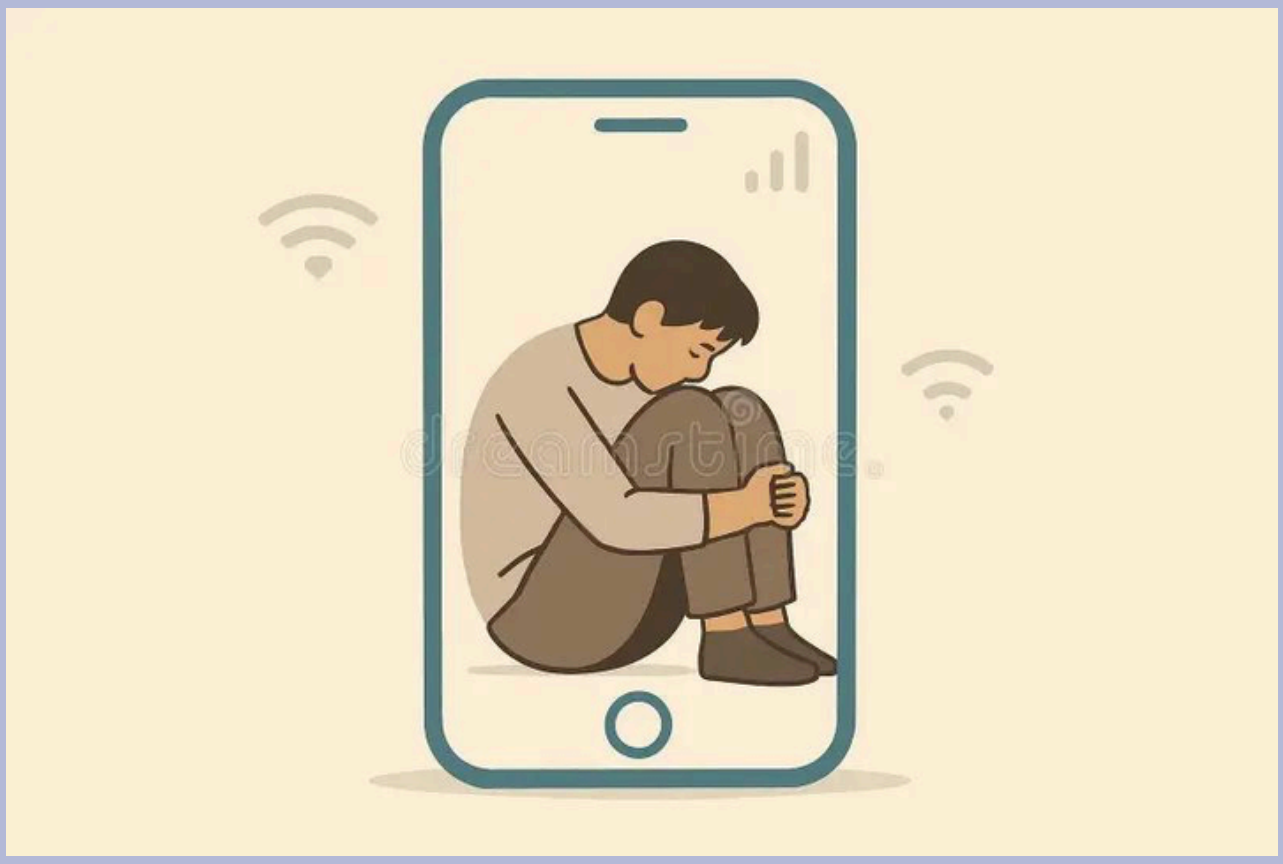
The Loneliest Generation: How Screens Replaced Conversations

An odd thing happens when you look closer: never have people been so linked across distances, yet isolation climbs like smoke through a chimney. Back in 2023, America’s top doctor called it an epidemic - loneliness spreading fast. It hits bodysystems about as hard as lighting up fifteen smokes every twenty-four hours. This isn't some exaggerated warning meant to shock - it’s rooted in studies examined and confirmed by experts.

What’s really happening here? Even though I can ring up someone in Tokyo late at night or blast a meme into a huge chat, loneliness keeps creeping in. Maybe it's because talking isn’t the same as feeling close. Our phones buzz nonstop - messages, updates, likes piling up. Yet real closeness means being known, flaws and all, not just showing off polished snapshots. That sort of moment slips away more each day.

The Substitution Effect

A study from the University of Pennsylvania showed people who cut social media down to half an hour each day felt less lonely and less depressed. Imagine realizing this - what we turn to for connection ends up pushing us further into isolation. Much like quenching thirst with seawater, it seems helpful at first, yet deepens the issue. The very act meant to bring closeness does quite the opposite.



Here’s why experts mention the ‘substitution effect.’ A moment lost to endlessInstagram browsing means less time sharing words face to face, noticing glances, picking up on gestures, or simply being quiet together without awkwardness. Online chats step into the space once filled by actual presence - yet never truly fill it. Though you might not notice, your mind does. Real talk lives elsewhere.

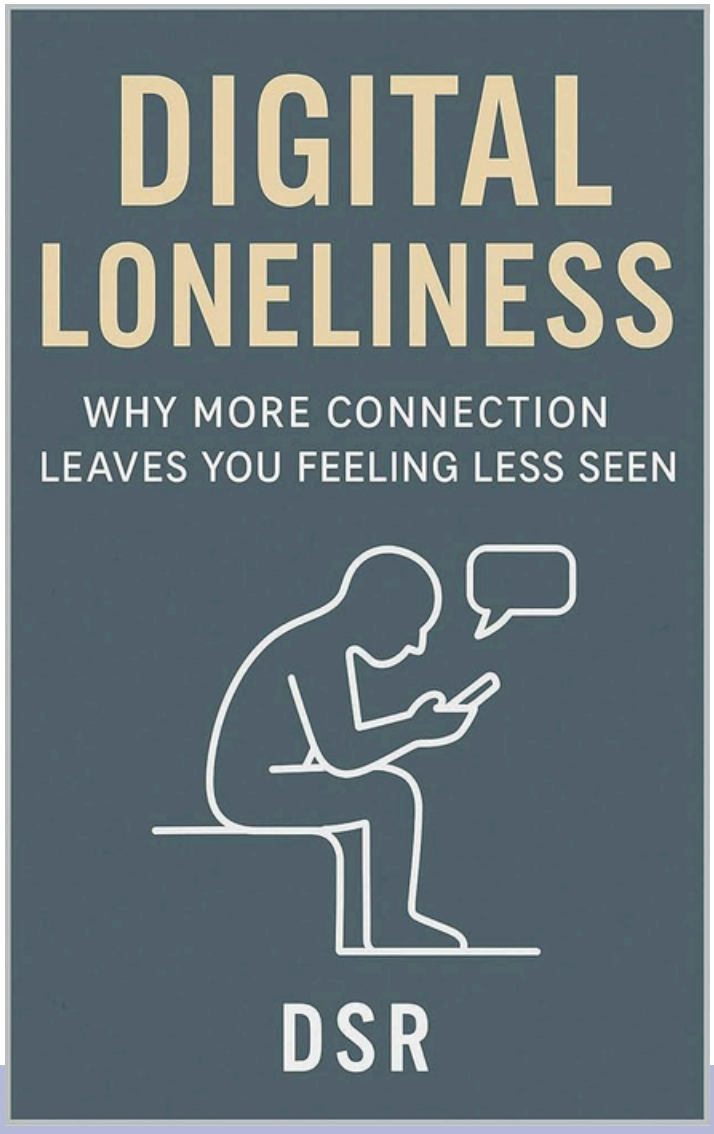
The Comparison Trap

Scrolling through feeds eats into moments meant for actual people, while quietly twisting self-perception. Research appearing in the Journal of Social and Clinical Psychology showed clear harm: more platform time led to lower mood, fueled by comparing oneself to others. Instead of simply seeing vacation images, a person silently stacks their everyday against edited snapshots far removed from truth.

Here it is, the bitter twist: folks showing off flawless days usually wrestle with doubt just like those scrolling through them. One plays for looks, another watches hoping to belong - both stuck pretending. A stage without real moments, where every person present carries quiet emptiness.

Stopping everything won't help - seeing clearly does. That pause when you notice your real life next to their polished moments? It counts. Spotting the mismatch changes how you feel, even if just for minutes. Awareness slips in quietly, yet shifts things. Not forever, but long enough to breathe differently.[1]

A study by Hunt and team in 2018 looked at how cutting back on social media affects mood. Instead of scrolling endlessly, participants who limited their time felt less lonely. Because they spent fewer hours online, symptoms of depression dropped. Although it might seem small, simply reducing usage made a noticeable difference. When people engaged more offline, emotional well-being improved.



[1] Murthy, V. (2023). "Our Epidemic of Loneliness and Isolation." U.S. Surgeon General Advisory. hhs.gov/surgeongeneral/priorities/connection/

The findings appeared in the Journal of Social and Clinical Psychology. With just ten weeks passing, changes were already clear. Since connection often happens face-to-face, digital distance helped some feel closer. As screen habits shifted, inner states followed. Even so, results varied slightly across individuals. After all, everyone uses platforms differently. Yet overall, stepping away brought relief.[2]

Arda Ü.

Digital Citizenship Ambassador



[2] Hunt, M.G., et al. (2018). "No More FOMO: Limiting Social Media Decreases Loneliness and Depression." Journal of Social and Clinical Psychology, 37(10), 751-768.

Works Cited

- Anderson, Clara. "From FOMO to JOMO: The New Digital Wellness." Mental Health Quarterly, vol. 15, no. 1, Jan. 2026, pp. 22-29.
- "The Neuroscience of Social Media." Psychology Today, 10 Feb. 2026, www.psychologytoday.com/neuroscience-social-media.
- Smith, Jordan. Digital Citizenship in the Modern Era. TechPress, 2025.
- World Health Organization. "Mental Health and Technology Use." WHO Reports, 14 Jan. 2026, www.who.int/reports/mental-health-tech.
- Güme, Sena. “Doomscrolling: A Review.” *Psikiyatride Güncel Yaklaşımlar/Psikiyatride Güncel Yaklaşımlar*, vol. 16, no. 4, 19 Feb. 2024, pp. 595–603, https://doi.org/10.18863/pgy.1416316.
- Johnston, Amber. “The Horrors of Doomscrolling & Its Impact on Mental Health.” *Ucdenver.edu*, 2024, www.ucdenver.edu/student/stories/library/healthy-happy-life/the-horrors-of-doomscrolling-its-impact-on-mental-health.
- Salamon, Maureen. “Doomscrolling Dangers.” *Harvard Health*, 1 Sept. 2024, www.health.harvard.edu/mind-and-mood/doomscrolling-dangers.
- Murthy, V. (2023). "Our Epidemic of Loneliness and Isolation." U.S. Surgeon General Advisory. hhs.gov/surgeongeneral/priorities/connection/
- Hunt, M.G., et al. (2018). "No More FOMO: Limiting Social Media Decreases Loneliness and Depression." Journal of Social and Clinical Psychology, 37(10), 751-768.